to him and his council in Calcutta. In 1905, he lamented how London often treated his government as if it were a negligible quantity, pointing out to Balfour that 'the Viceroy of India is not an agent whom you send out merely to execute your orders or to act as the instrument of a policy conceived.'[122] For his part, Balfour 'once wrote that Curzon regarded the Secretary of State [for India] not as the Minister responsible to Parliament for the government of India but as the Viceroy's diplomatic representative at the Court of St. James'.[123] Come 1918, Curzon would find the roles reversed, when he was occupying the Foreign Office and the Indian government disagreed with policy emanating from Whitehall. One would have thought that his experience as viceroy would have provided Curzon with an empathy and an understanding for the frustrations of the Indian government in the post-war period, when it complained of being ignored by London. Ironically enough, however, when it came to it, Curzon was just as willing to ignore the voices of dissent in India as his predecessors had been.

In August 1905, Curzon would end up resigning following a dispute with General Kitchener over the relatively minor matter of the power of the military member of the viceroy's council. As viceroy, Curzon had fought incessantly with the Home government to preserve his prerogative to act on matters which he believed to be in his sole remit and when London supported Kitchener in this affair it was too much for him to bear. Later, as chair of the Eastern Committee he would balk at any attempt to reform the committee that appeared to limit his powers over it. As foreign secretary, he would insist on having his own way over Britain's international relations, jealously guarding his authority within the government. He would cajole and bully any who opposed him, and frequently threaten to resign if his wishes were not granted (although 1905 was, in fact, the only time he carried through the threat). For, wherever he was, whatever position within government he occupied, Curzon always believed that he knew best and should be listened to. His ambition, stubbornness and relentless nature, combined with his experience of Asian affairs meant that Curzon's was nearly always the loudest voice in government when it came to Britain's foreign policy in this region. His continual lauding of his own expertise on Asia and the Middle East even became something of a standing joke among his colleagues in government. An encounter during a Cabinet discussion summarises all: as the discussion moved on to Persia, Curzon cleared his